WHY REKHA GUPTA FOR CM

She may be a first-time MLA, but new CM Rekha Gupta cut her teeth in the hurly-burly of Delhi University politics, becoming DUSU president from the ABVP in the mid-90s. The first woman chief minister pick in the Modi era (after Anandiben Patel retired in Gujarat), she was up against giant killer Parvesh Verma in the race for the top job. The fact that the RSS put its weight behind Rekha—she's a long-time Sangh worker and confidante of *sarkaryawaha* Dattatreya Hosabale—tilted the balance in her favour.

The BJP wanted someone well-versed with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), to wrest it from AAP. That Rekha was a woman, from the Punjabi-speaking Baniya community and a three-time councillor, made her perfect for the job. It also shows that voter outreach is still top of the mind for the BJP and that they will be relentless against AAP. The new CM is known for her organisational skills and "aggressive drive", evidence of which is a video that has gone viral from her time as an MCD councillor. Rekha will also be an asset nationally in the campaign to take over the few pockets of resistance left in the country, such as states like Punjab and Bengal.

- Anilesh S. Mahajan



X/@LambaAlka

GREAT RIVALRY A picture tweeted by the Congress's Alka Lamba (right) of the new CM from their Delhi University days

Welfare challenges: Welfare programmes spelt out in the pre-poll promises hold the key. The BJP has committed to a monthly allowance of Rs 2,500 to eligible women and a one-time payment of Rs 21,000 to pregnant women. The new CM has said she will release the first payment for women by March 8, which is just two weeks away. This will be a test of both administration and finances. Locating the rightful beneficiaries across a city as large as Delhi poses a big challenge; the freebie entails a payout of Rs 11,500 crore annually, and will call for careful management.

THE BJP IS IN POWER, SO THE EXCUSE THAT LAW AND ORDER IN DELHI IS UNDER THE CENTRE'S JURISDICTION NO LONGER HOLDS

Crumbling infrastructure: Delhi's roads remain problematic. Even Kejriwal admitted during the poll campaign that his government could not fix them as promised. Delhi government data suggests that over 500 km of roads are in need of repair. The new regime also faces a peculiar political situation. Even though AAP lost the assembly election, as of now it still runs the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the civic body entrusted with keeping the city clean. So the BJP government will not only have to handle opposition in the House, but also a hostile MCD outside.

Water and energy issues: Delhi requires 1,290 million gallons of water per day (MGD), yet produces only around 1,000 MGD. The city relies heavily on water from neighboring states and that supply has remained unchanged since 1994. The solutions are complex: finishing current water treatment plant projects, promoting water conservation and harvesting in every home and business and, perhaps the most challenging of all, cleaning the Yamuna river. Regarding electricity, the BJP has promised free power up to 200 units and a 50 per cent subsidy beyond that. Balancing these promises will be a challenge.

Restoring the Yamuna: The BJP has promised to clean the very polluted river within three years. Kejriwal had always blamed upstream Haryana for discharging pollutants into the Yamuna. The BJP is also in power in the neighbouring state so the new CM cannot cite that reason. There are big challenges—untreated sewage has to be connected to treatment plants to ensure cleaner discharge into the river. The BJP has also promised a sterling riverfront experience.

Law and order: Making Delhi safe for women is a priority. Delhi Police wants 25 per cent of its force to be women in the near future. The new government will have to work on an old apparatus, stress community policing, speed up emergency responses besides using technology to keep the city safe. The